SAT / READING & WRITING / FREE GUIDE

SAT Grammar Rules You Actually Need

A practical reference for sentence boundaries, agreement, and punctuation.

By TestPrepUnraveled • Updated September 12, 2026 • 5 min read

Find the sentence skeleton

Start with the subject and its main verb. Ignore interrupting phrases for a moment. In “The box of old notebooks is heavy,” box is the subject, so the singular verb is is. The plural word notebooks does not control the verb.

Separate complete thoughts correctly

Two independent clauses can be separated by a period or semicolon. They can also be joined with a comma plus a coordinating conjunction such as and or but. A comma alone creates a comma splice. A dependent clause cannot stand as a complete sentence.

Use punctuation for a reason

A colon can introduce an explanation or list after a complete clause. Paired commas or dashes can surround a nonessential interruption. Do not put a comma between a subject and its verb merely because the subject phrase is long.

Check meaning after mechanics

Verb tense should match the passage’s timeline. Pronouns should refer clearly to a noun. Modifiers should sit beside what they describe: “Walking to school, Mina noticed a mural” makes Mina the person walking.

YOUR DESK-SIDE REFERENCE

Quick reference

Check	Rule	Example
Agreement	Match the verb to the subject	The collection of maps is large.
Semicolon	Join two independent clauses	The rain stopped; we left.
Colon	Begin with a complete clause	We needed one tool: a ruler.
Possession	Singular owner: apostrophe + s	the student’s notebook
Parallelism	Keep list items in the same form	reading, drafting, and revising

Original worked example

Choose the correct verb: “The list of recommended books (is / are) on the desk.”

Choose is. The subject is list, a singular noun. The phrase of recommended books describes the list but does not change its number.

A tip worth keeping

Read the full sentence before choosing punctuation. A pause in speech is not enough evidence for a comma.

Your quick checklist

- Identify the exact task before working.
- Show the reasoning, not just the answer.
- Review the mistake and try a new example.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Try it yourself

These original questions were written for this guide. Try each one before reading the answer key.

1. Fix this sentence: “The library closed, we studied at home.”

2. Which works: “After finishing the project.” or “After finishing the project, Leo rested.”?

3. Choose: “The students revised, edited, and (proofreading / proofread) their essays.”

Answers & explanations

1. One option: “The library closed, so we studied at home.” A comma plus so joins the two independent clauses.

2. The second is complete. The introductory dependent phrase needs an independent clause.

3. Proofread. It keeps the three verbs parallel in the past tense.

Keep your prep current

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